

TPL-16 · FREE TEMPLATES

Lessons learned and closeout register

The fields that make a lesson actionable, and the closeout checklist that captures what the next project needs

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

A lessons register built around the two fields most registers omit — the artefact that must change, and the process owner outside the project who owns that artefact — plus the implementation status that makes the whole thing measurable. It comes with a four-part closeout checklist covering commercial, financial and records closeout, and the benchmarking data capture that has to happen before the team disperses, because after that it is unrecoverable.

— About this document

Document	TPL-16
Series	Free Templates
Version	1.0
Status	draft
Date	2026-08-04
Unresolved placeholders	0

Notice. This document is an educational publication of Project Controls Institute Global, Inc., and does not constitute accounting, tax, legal, financial or other professional advice. It must not be relied upon as such. Where a topic depends on the contract or the governing law, entitlement and treatment vary by jurisdiction; take local advice.

Standards. Standards and frameworks are referred to by name and described in this publication's own words. No standard's text, tables, diagrams or question banks are reproduced. All trademarks remain the property of their respective owners, and no endorsement by any standards body, employer or vendor is implied or should be inferred.

Status. Project Controls Institute Global, Inc. is a Delaware Non-Stock Corporation. The Institute has been developed with reference to ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles and is **not accredited** by ANAB, IAS or any other accreditation body. It intends to seek 501(c)(3) recognition, which has not been granted. No governmental approval, academic equivalence, or guaranteed employment, promotion or salary outcome is claimed or implied.

Examples. All worked examples are illustrative and fictional. Figures are chosen to demonstrate a method, not to describe any real project, organisation or market. Sample examination items, where they appear, are study material maintained separately from any live examination bank.

Completeness. Passages marked **[CONFIRM: ...]** are operational or market facts that have not yet been confirmed from a cited source. A document carrying them is a working draft and is not approved for publication.

© 2026 Project Controls Institute Global, Inc. · All rights reserved.

Contents

1. When to use this	4
2. How to complete it.....	4
2.1 Separate context, event, cause and instruction	4
2.2 Route it to an artefact and an owner	5
2.3 Record the positives, and mean it.....	5
2.4 Measure implementation, and publish the rate	5
2.5 Capture benchmarking data with its definitions attached	5
3. The template	6
3.1 Part 1 — the lessons register	6
3.2 Part 2 — summary measures.....	7
3.3 Part 3 — the closeout checklist	8
3.4 Part 4 — benchmarking data capture	9
3.5 Pasting it into a spreadsheet.....	10
4. Worked fragment.....	10
5. Common mistakes	12
6. Adapting it.....	13
6.1 Closing the project.....	13
Related	14
Sources and standards.....	14
Status and version	14

Lessons learned and closeout register

In one paragraph. A lessons register built around the two fields most registers omit — the artefact that must change, and the process owner outside the project who owns that artefact — plus the implementation status that makes the whole thing measurable. It comes with a four-part closeout checklist covering commercial, financial and records closeout, and the benchmarking data capture that has to happen before the team disperses, because after that it is unrecoverable.

Who this is for. Project controls managers, project managers and commercial managers closing a project or a phase; the process owners in the wider organisation who receive the lessons; and the estimators and planners who will need the benchmarking data on the next bid.

— 1. When to use this

From the start of the project, not at the end of it. A lesson written eleven months after the event has lost the two things that made it useful: the detail of what actually happened, and the person who saw it. Open the register at mobilisation and add to it as things happen. The end-of-project workshop then becomes a review of a register rather than a memory test conducted under time pressure by people who have already been assigned elsewhere.

At every phase transition, because a lesson from the design phase is worth most to the design phase of the next project, and it will be forgotten by the time this one finishes.

At closeout, for the checklist in §3.3 and — most urgently — the benchmarking capture in §3.4. There is a window between the end of the work and the dispersal of the team in which the data that makes the next estimate better can still be collected. After that window closes, it can be reconstructed only expensively and badly.

The instrument answers one question: what will be different next time, and who is making it different? A register that cannot answer the second half is a record of experience, not a mechanism for improvement.

— 2. How to complete it

2.1 Separate context, event, cause and instruction

Four fields do the work, and merging them is why most registers are unreadable.

Context (column G) is what a stranger on a different project needs in order to decide whether this applies to them. Contract type, phase, scale, the arrangement that mattered. Without it every lesson reads as either universal or irrelevant, and both readings mean it is ignored.

What happened (column H) is the observable fact, dated. No characterisation.

Why (column I) separates the immediate cause from the condition that allowed it. This is the most valuable field in the register and the one most often filled with a restatement of the event. A diver-

gence between two contract documents is the immediate cause; the absence of any step in the pre-contract review that reconciles them is the condition, and only the second one can be fixed. Most lessons that never get implemented failed here: they identified something that cannot be changed rather than something that can.

What to do differently (column L) is an instruction, testable by someone who was not there. "Improve communication with the design team" is not one. "Add a step to the pre-contract review requiring a documented reconciliation of the specification hierarchy, with divergences either priced or listed as exclusions" is.

2.2 Route it to an artefact and an owner

Columns M and N are the mechanism, and their absence is why lessons registers fail.

Column M — where it must land. Name the artefact that has to change: a procedure, a checklist line, an estimating norm, a standard scope of work, a tender question, an induction, a contract term, a schedule fragnet, a template. A lesson that does not change an artefact changes nothing, because the next project will be run by different people reading the same documents.

Column N — the process owner. The named role **outside the project** that owns that artefact. This is the field that makes a lesson real. A lesson routed to "the project team" dies with the project. A lesson routed to the person who owns the pre-contract review checklist arrives somewhere that outlives the job.

If no artefact can be named, the honest options are to record it as an observation rather than a lesson, or to work harder at column I until a changeable condition emerges. Both are better than a register entry that will never be actioned and will be counted as though it might be.

2.3 Record the positives, and mean it

Column K distinguishes what to repeat from what to avoid. A register containing only failures teaches the organisation that submitting to it is dangerous, and submissions stop. It also loses genuinely valuable information: the sequencing decision that saved six weeks is as transferable as the one that cost six, and considerably easier to get adopted.

2.4 Measure implementation, and publish the rate

The implementation rate in §3.2 is the only number that tells you whether the lessons process is real. A register with 140 entries and an implementation rate of four per cent is a filing cabinet with a search function. Publish the rate to the process owners quarterly. It is uncomfortable, and it is the only thing that reliably changes behaviour, because it moves the accountability from the project that raised the lesson to the function that received it.

2.5 Capture benchmarking data with its definitions attached

The benchmarking block in §3.4 is the part of closeout that pays for itself and the part most often skipped. The trap is that raw figures without their definitional metadata are worse than nothing: they look comparable, they are used as though they are, and they produce estimates that are confidently wrong.

Every captured figure needs its scope boundary, its currency and base date, its escalation treatment and the definition of its denominator recorded alongside it. A productivity figure without a definition of what was included in the hours is not data.

— 3. The template

Four parts: the lessons register, its summary measures, the closeout checklist, and the benchmarking capture.

3.1 Part 1 — the lessons register

Col	Field	What goes in it
A	Lesson ID	LL-031 and so on. Permanent
B	Date raised	The date the entry was created, not the date of the event
C	Raised by	Named individual
D	Phase	When it occurred: business case · design · procurement · construction · commissioning · handover · closeout
E	Function	Cost · Schedule · Risk · Commercial · Procurement · Engineering · Construction · Commissioning · Digital and data · Health and safety
F	Category	The project's own taxonomy, agreed at mobilisation
G	Context	What a reader on a different project needs to judge whether it applies to them
H	What happened	The observable facts, dated, without characterisation
I	Why	The immediate cause, and separately the condition that allowed it
J	Effect	Quantified where possible: cost, working days, rework hours, incidents
K	Repeat or avoid	Repeat · Avoid. Both are lessons
L	What to do differently	An instruction, testable by someone who was not there
M	Where it must land	The named artefact that has to change
N	Process owner	The named role outside the project that owns that artefact
O	Change required	The specific edit to the named artefact
P	Owner response	Accepted · Rejected · Deferred, with the date and the reason
Q	Status	Proposed · Accepted · In progress · Implemented · Rejected · Superseded
R	Implementation evidence	The version of the artefact that now carries the change
S	Date verified	The date the change was confirmed in the artefact
T	Verified by	Named individual, not the person who raised it
U	Applicable to	Project types, contract types, sectors — the transferability statement
V	Confidence	Single observation · Repeated on this project · Seen across projects
W	Benchmarking record	Link to the Part 4 capture where the lesson has data behind it
X	Notes	

3.2 Part 2 — summary measures

Report_Date is a named cell holding the reporting cut-off, used instead of **TODAY()** so that a saved report still reads the same next quarter.

Elapsed days is a helper column — put it in column Y, immediately after the register.

Field	Formula in words	Spreadsheet expression
Elapsed days (column Y)	Days from raising to verification, or to the report date if not yet verified	<code>=IF(\$B2="", "", IF(\$S2="", Report_Date-\$B2, \$S2-\$B2))</code>
Lessons raised	Count of lesson IDs	<code>=COUNTA(\$A\$2:\$A\$500)</code>
Implementation rate	Implemented lessons divided by the lessons that have a status recorded; blank if none has one	<code>=IF(COUNTIF(\$Q\$2:\$Q\$500, "<>")=0, "", COUNTIF(\$Q\$2:\$Q\$500, "Implemented")/COUNTIF(\$Q\$2:\$Q\$500, "<>"))</code>
Rejection rate	Rejected lessons divided by the lessons that have a status recorded; blank if none has one	<code>=IF(COUNTIF(\$Q\$2:\$Q\$500, "<>")=0, "", COUNTIF(\$Q\$2:\$Q\$500, "Rejected")/COUNTIF(\$Q\$2:\$Q\$500, "<>"))</code>
Median days to implementation	The median of the elapsed days across implemented lessons; blank if there are none	<code>=IF(COUNTIF(\$Q\$2:\$Q\$500, "Implemented")=0, "", MEDIAN(IF(\$Q\$2:\$Q\$500="Implemented", \$Y\$2:\$Y\$500)))</code> , entered as an array formula
Lessons with no named artefact	Count of rows that have a lesson ID but no entry in the artefact column	<code>=COUNTIFS(\$A\$2:\$A\$500, "<>", \$M\$2:\$M\$500, "")</code>

The last measure is the health check on the register itself. A rising count of lessons with no named artefact means the register is filling with observations, and the implementation rate will follow it down.

A rejection rate of zero is not good news. It usually means process owners are accepting everything and implementing selectively, which produces an accepted-but-not-implemented backlog that nobody is counting. A rejection with a recorded reason is a decision; silent non-implementation is a leak.

3.3 Part 3 — the closeout checklist

Each item takes a status, an owner, a date and an evidence reference. The four groups are separate because they close at different times and involve different people.

Commercial closeout

- Final account position agreed, or the outstanding items listed with a route and a date for each.
- Every change on the change order log closed: agreed, withdrawn, rejected or formally in dispute.
- Claims resolved, withdrawn, or transferred to a named owner with the record set preserved.
- Retention release dates diarised, with the amounts and the trigger events recorded.
- Warranties, guarantees and bonds either released or diarised for release, with expiry dates held by a named owner.
- Subcontract and supply final accounts settled, and any contra-charges or back-charges concluded.
- Defects liability or rectification period start and end dates recorded, with the responsible owner named.
- Insurance position closed or converted to run-off cover as the contract requires.
- Outstanding notices either withdrawn in writing or deliberately preserved, with the decision recorded.

Financial closeout

- Final cost report reconciled to the general ledger, with any unreconciled difference explained in writing.
- Accruals reversed or converted, with none left standing against a closed cost code.
- Open commitments and purchase orders closed or transferred.
- Cost codes closed to further posting, with the date and the authoriser recorded.
- The accounting treatment of the completed asset or the completed contract concluded with the finance function — noting that recognition, capitalisation and tax treatment vary by jurisdiction and by accounting framework, and none of them should be assumed from another project.
- Final cash position stated, with outstanding receivables listed and owned.
- Currency and hedging positions closed with the finance function where any were held.
- Project bank account or ledger closed, or the closure date diarised.

Records closeout

- The record set indexed against a stated structure, with a named custodian.
- Retention period identified from the contract and the applicable law, which differ — record the period applied and its source, and do not carry over a period from another project.
- Access controls set, so that the records can be found by someone who was not on the project.
- The as-built programme and every schedule update preserved in native format, not only as reports.

- The correspondence and notice register preserved with its index.
- Where any dispute is live or reasonably anticipated, the relevant records preserved under a documented hold, and the hold's owner named.
- Personal data handled according to the applicable regime, which varies by jurisdiction — record what was retained, what was deleted, and on what basis.
- AI-generated artefacts identified as such, with their validation records preserved alongside them, so that a later reader can tell what was machine-produced and who accepted it.

Benchmarking capture — see Part 4. Its place in this checklist is a single item with a hard rule attached: it is complete before the team disperses, or it is not complete.

3.4 Part 4 — benchmarking data capture

Two blocks. The measures, and the metadata without which the measures are unusable.

Measure	Formula in words	Spreadsheet expression
Cost outturn ratio	Final outturn cost divided by the sanction budget; blank if the budget is unset	=IF(N(Sanction_Budget)=0,"",Final_Outturn_Cost/Sanction_Budget)
Schedule outturn ratio	Actual duration divided by baseline duration, in working days; blank if the baseline is unset	=IF(N(Baseline_Duration_Days)=0,"",Actual_Duration_Days/Baseline_Duration_Days)
Change value as a share of the original contract	Total agreed change value divided by the original contract value; blank if that value is unset	=IF(N(Original_Contract_Value)=0,"",Total_Agreed_Change_Value/Original_Contract_Value)
Contingency drawdown ratio	Contingency drawn divided by contingency held at sanction; blank if none was held	=IF(N(Contingency_Held_At_Sanction)=0,"",Contingency_Drawn/Contingency_Held_At_Sanction)
Indirect cost share	Indirect cost divided by total cost; blank if total cost is unset	=IF(N(Total_Cost)=0,"",Indirect_Cost/Total_Cost)
Design growth	Final quantity divided by tender quantity, per measured item; blank if the tender quantity is unset	=IF(N(\$B2)=0,"", \$C2/\$B2)
Productivity achieved	Output quantity divided by hours expended, per discipline; blank if hours are unset	=IF(N(\$E2)=0,"", \$D2/\$E2)
Confidence at outturn	The percentile at which the actual outturn sat in the sanction-stage risk analysis	Read from the analysis; record the analysis reference alongside it

Also capture, as raw figures rather than ratios: final quantities with their units; unit rates achieved; actual durations of standard activity types against the estimated durations; and the actual elapsed time between key milestones.

The metadata, recorded against every figure above:

Field	Why it is needed
Scope boundary	What is inside the number and what is outside — client costs, land, enabling works, escalation, contingency
Currency and base date	A rate with no base date cannot be escalated to today
Escalation treatment	Whether the figure is as-spent or rebased, and to when
Denominator definition	What "hours" includes: supervision, travel, rework, standing time
Measurement standard	The rule under which quantities were measured
Contract type	Lump sum, remeasurable, reimbursable, target cost — the ratios mean different things under each
Sector and geography	For like-for-like comparison
Data quality	Whether the figure is from the ledger, from a report, or estimated at closeout

The last row is the one that saves a future estimator. A figure reconstructed at closeout from memory and a figure taken from the ledger should not sit in a benchmarking database looking identical.

3.5 Pasting it into a spreadsheet

Copy the header line into cell A1 and split on the pipe character.

```
Lesson ID|Date raised|Raised by|Phase|Function|Category|Context|What happened|Why|Effect|Repeat or avoid|
What to do differently|Where it must land|Process owner|Change required|Owner response|Status|Implementa-
tion evidence|Date verified|Verified by|Applicable to|Confidence|Benchmarking record|Notes
```

4. Worked fragment

Illustrative figures. Currency-neutral units. Working days on a five-day calendar. Report date 30 June 2026.

One lesson. Fields shown in the order of §3.1; **Raised by**, **Category**, **Verified by** and **Notes** are omitted here for space.

Field	Entry
Lesson ID	LL-031
Date raised	12 March 2026
Phase	Procurement
Function	Commercial
Context	A design-and-build package on a lump-sum contract where the employer's requirements referenced a performance specification for the fire alarm system and the contractor's proposals priced a prescriptive scope
What happened	The divergence was first identified at the design review eleven weeks after contract award. Resolution took a further nine weeks and required re-tendering of two related subcontract packages
Why	Immediate cause: a documentary divergence between two documents both forming part of the contract. Condition that allowed it: the pre-contract review had no step requiring the specification hierarchy and any divergence to be reconciled before execution
Effect	148,000 in additional design and abortive procurement cost; 15 working days of delay to package handover
Repeat or avoid	Avoid
What to do differently	Add a mandatory step to the pre-contract review requiring a documented reconciliation of the specification hierarchy, with every divergence either priced or listed as an exclusion, signed by a named reviewer
Where it must land	The pre-contract review checklist, section on documents forming the contract
Process owner	Head of Commercial, as owner of the pre-contract review checklist
Change required	New checklist item with a named reviewer and a mandatory output
Owner response	Accepted, 2 April 2026
Status	Implemented
Implementation evidence	Pre-contract review checklist version 4.2
Date verified	4 June 2026
Applicable to	Design-and-build and engineer-procure-construct packages where employer's requirements and contractor's proposals both form part of the contract
Confidence	Repeated on this project — a comparable divergence arose on the mechanical package

Elapsed days from raising to verification: 12 March 2026 to 4 June 2026 is **84 days**.

Note what makes this entry work. The condition in the "why" field is changeable, which is why there is a named artefact in the next field. The instruction is testable by someone who was not there. The process owner sits outside the project, so the change survives demobilisation. And the entry ends with an artefact version and a verification date, which is what allows it to be counted as implemented rather than accepted.

Benchmarking capture extract

Measure	Inputs	Result
Change value as a share of the original contract	$2,640,000 \div 24,000,000$	0.110, or 11.0 %
Contingency drawdown ratio	$2,150,000 \div 1,800,000$	1.194, or 119.4 %
Schedule outturn ratio	$712 \div 640$ working days	1.113, or 111.3 %
Cost outturn ratio	$28,900,000 \div 26,500,000$	1.091, or 109.1 %

Metadata for all four: figures at the sanction base date; no escalation adjustment applied; client-side costs and land excluded; single contract currency; lump-sum contract; figures taken from the ledger except the schedule outturn, which is taken from the as-built programme.

The substitutions. Change share: $2,640,000 \div 24,000,000 = 0.110$. Contingency drawdown: $2,150,000 \div 1,800,000 = 1.194$ — the project drew about nineteen per cent more contingency than it held, which is a single sentence a benchmarking database should be able to produce and almost none can. Schedule outturn: $712 \div 640 = 1.1125$, reported as 1.113. Cost outturn: $28,900,000 \div 26,500,000 = 1.0906$, reported as 1.091.

Read the last two together. The project overran its sanction budget by 9.1 % and its baseline duration by 11.3 %, and it drew 19.4 % more contingency than it held. Those three figures are more use to the next estimate than any narrative, and all three become uncollectable within about six weeks of handover.

— 5. Common mistakes

Opening the register at the end. The lessons that survive to a closeout workshop are the ones that were still annoying somebody in the final month. Everything from the first year is gone.

Lessons that name no artefact. "Engage stakeholders earlier" cannot be implemented because there is nothing to change. Column M is the test, and the count of blanks in it is the register's health.

Routing to the project. A lesson owned by the project team is closed by demobilisation. The process owner must be outside the project.

A register of failures only. It teaches people that contributing is risky, and submissions dry up within two projects.

Restating the event in the "why" field. "The divergence was not identified" is not a cause; it is the event again. Keep asking until you reach a condition somebody can change.

Counting raised, not implemented. "We captured 140 lessons" is an input measure and it is the one that gets reported. The output measure is the implementation rate, and it is usually an order of magnitude less impressive.

Accepting everything. A rejection rate of zero with a low implementation rate means process owners are being polite. A recorded rejection with a reason is a better outcome than a silent acceptance.

Skipping the benchmarking capture. It is last on the list, it happens when everyone has been reassigned, and it is the item with the shortest window. Diarise it before the completion date, not after.

Benchmarking figures with no definitions. Numbers that look comparable and are not do more damage than no numbers, because they will be used with confidence.

Records closed on last project's rules. Retention periods, data protection obligations and accounting treatment differ by contract and by jurisdiction. Record the source of the rule you applied.

— 6. Adapting it

Safe to change. The phase and function taxonomies, the status list, and the closeout groups — add a technical or operational closeout group if the project hands over an asset that must be operated, and a stakeholder or consents group where permissions must be discharged or transferred.

Safe to add. A cross-project view that groups lessons by artefact rather than by project, which is how a process owner actually wants to receive them — several projects pointing at one checklist is a much stronger case than one project pointing at it. A quarterly implementation report to the process owners. A field linking a lesson to the risk that was realised, and another linking it to the change that resulted, so the three registers reconcile.

Do not change. The separation of the immediate cause from the condition. The named artefact and the external process owner. The implementation status and the verification evidence. And the rule that the benchmarking capture happens before the team disperses — every organisation that has skipped it has paid for the same data twice, once by not collecting it and again by estimating without it.

6.1 Closing the project

- The lessons register was open from mobilisation, and entries are dated across the whole project, not clustered in the last two months.
- Every lesson has a context a stranger could use, a changeable condition in the "why" field, and a testable instruction.
- Every lesson names an artefact and a process owner outside the project — and the count of blanks in the artefact column has been reported.
- Every process owner has responded, with rejections recorded and reasoned rather than left silent.
- The implementation rate has been calculated and sent to the process owners, not only to the project.
- All four closeout groups are complete, with an owner, a date and an evidence reference against each item.
- Retention periods, data protection treatment and accounting treatment each record the source of the rule applied, rather than carrying one over from another project.
- The benchmarking capture is complete, with metadata against every figure and a data-quality marker distinguishing ledger figures from reconstructions.
- The as-built programme, the schedule updates and the correspondence register are preserved in native format with a named custodian.
- Somebody who will run the next project has read the register and said which entries they will act on.

— Related

- [BPG-20 – Closeout, lessons learned and benchmarking](#) — the method behind this instrument, including how to run a lessons workshop that produces conditions rather than complaints
- [BPG-19 – Project controls assurance and health checks](#) — the assurance view of whether a lessons process is real
- [TPL-15 – Project controls health check](#) — the review whose findings route into this register at project end
- [BPG-10 – Contingency and management reserve](#) — where the contingency drawdown ratio captured here goes to work on the next project
- [BPG-09 – Estimate at completion – choosing and defending a method](#) — the forecasting practice the outturn ratios are captured to improve

— Sources and standards

This is an original instrument developed by the Institute. It reproduces no third-party template, form or checklist. The closeout groups, the register fields and the benchmarking measures are the Institute's own formulation, offered for adaptation. Retention periods, data protection obligations, revenue recognition, capitalisation and tax treatment all vary by contract, by jurisdiction and by accounting framework; this template requires that the source of the rule applied is recorded and presents no jurisdiction's treatment as universal.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.